



ROOT CAUSE UNLOCKED

Unlock Your *Fibromyalgia*

Real Pain, Normal Labs, and What Actually Moves the Needle

A guide for anyone who has been told their bloodwork looks fine, been handed a prescription and a shrug, and left the appointment with the same pain they walked in with.

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Before anything else: your pain is real

Two things are true at once, and most books on this subject only tell you one of them.

Your pain is real. It is not imagined, not exaggerated, and not a personality trait. There is a measurable difference in how your nervous system processes pain signals, and it has a name.

And there is no cure. Anyone selling you one is lying to you, and the people with fibromyalgia I have met have already been lied to enough.

What sits between those two facts is a large amount of genuinely useful ground: what is actually happening, which of the things you have been told are wrong, what has real evidence behind it, and what a realistic good outcome looks like. That is what this book is for.

A note on what this book leaves out. It does not tell you what supplements to take, what to eat, or how to read your lab results. Those are the three companion guides, the diet guide, the supplement guide, and the lab guide, and they are built to be used rather than read. This book is the understanding. If you want the doing, that is where it lives.

Red flags that need medical attention, not a self-help plan

Fibromyalgia does not cause these. If you have any of them, they need evaluation on their own terms.

- Fever, night sweats, or unexplained weight loss
- Joint swelling, redness, or heat, as distinct from aching
- Sudden or severe weakness, particularly on one side
- New numbness with loss of bladder or bowel control
- A rash accompanying joint pain
- Pain that is truly new, truly localized, and steadily worsening

Widespread aching that migrates, fatigue that sleep does not fix, and pain that varies with weather, stress, and activity is the fibromyalgia pattern. The list above is not.

The pain nobody can find

You know the appointment. You describe pain that is everywhere and nowhere in particular. You say you are exhausted in a way that sleeping does not touch. You mention the fog, the way words go missing mid-sentence. The physician runs a panel. The panel comes back clean.

And then something happens that does more damage than the pain: the clean panel gets treated as an answer instead of a finding. You get told there is nothing wrong. Some people get told it more gently than others. A great many get told, in one phrasing or another, that it might be stress.

Here is the thing that appointment got backwards. **Normal labs are not evidence against fibromyalgia. They are the expected result.** There is no blood test that confirms it. That is a known feature of the condition, not a hole in your story, and a clinician who understands fibromyalgia is not surprised by a clean panel. They are checking for something else entirely, which is the subject of one of the keys below.

Fibromyalgia is common. A 2026 systematic review of prevalence in the general population and at-risk groups notes that estimates vary widely worldwide, driven by differences in diagnostic criteria and study methods.¹ The variability itself tells you something: this is a condition defined clinically rather than by a test, and where you draw the line changes how many people fall inside it.

What follows are eight things worth understanding. Not a protocol. Understanding, which is the part that has been missing.

What is actually happening is a change in pain processing, not damage in the tissue

The single most useful idea in this book is that fibromyalgia is a problem with the volume knob, not the speakers.

In most pain, something is damaged and nerves report it. In fibromyalgia the reporting system itself has changed. Signals that should register as pressure register as pain. Signals that should fade keep firing. The medical term for this mechanism is **central sensitisation**, and a 2026 review of the year's research states plainly that it remains the main neurobiological mechanism, supported by the accumulated evidence.²

There is a broader category name worth knowing too, because you will encounter it: **nociplastic pain**, defined as altered nociceptive processing without clear tissue damage or a lesion in the sensory system. Fibromyalgia is the flagship example.

Why this matters practically, in three ways.

It explains why imaging and bloodwork are clean. They are looking at the speakers.

It explains why the pain moves, varies, and does not respect anatomical boundaries the way an injury does. A sensitized system responds to context, such as sleep, stress, weather, and exertion.

And it explains why treatments aimed at tissue tend to disappoint, while treatments aimed at the nervous system tend to do better. That single insight redirects a lot of wasted effort.

What it does not mean. Central sensitisation does not make the pain psychological. Central sensitisation is a change in how a physical system processes signals. Saying pain is generated centrally is not the same as saying it is imagined, and anyone who slides from one to the other is either confused or being unkind.

Your labs are normal because that is what fibromyalgia looks like, and testing still matters

If there is no confirmatory test, why test at all?

Because testing in fibromyalgia is there to find the conditions that look exactly like it and are treated completely differently.

Hypothyroidism produces fatigue, aching, and cognitive fog. So does low B12, and low B12 can also produce nerve symptoms that are permanent if left long enough. Iron deficiency produces exhaustion and poor exercise tolerance well before it produces anemia. Vitamin D deficiency produces diffuse musculoskeletal pain. Inflammatory arthritis in its early stages can present as widespread ache before joints visibly change. Sleep apnea produces unrefreshing sleep, fatigue, and pain amplification, and is routinely missed in women.

Every one of those is more treatable than fibromyalgia. Every one is a genuine miss if it is not looked for.

So the sequence that makes sense is: rule out the mimics, then treat what remains. A clean panel after a thorough look is a useful, meaningful result. A clean panel from a basic screen ordered to end the conversation is not the same thing, and it is worth knowing which one you got.

The companion lab guide covers exactly which panels answer which question, what the numbers mean, and includes a request list you can hand to a clinician. I am deliberately not reproducing it here.

One thing to be careful about. There is a claim circulating that fibromyalgia is caused by insulin resistance, based on a 2019 paper. **That paper was retracted.** It is not evidence, and it should not be the basis of anyone's treatment decisions. I mention it only because it still circulates widely and you deserve to know what you are looking at when you meet it.

Sleep and pain feed each other, and this loop is the most actionable thing in the book

Almost everyone with fibromyalgia sleeps badly. The usual assumption is that pain wrecks sleep. That is true, and it is only half the loop.

A study tracking daily sleep and pain ratings in chronic pain patients found a genuinely **bidirectional** relationship: a night of poor sleep was followed by increased pain the next day, and a day of increased pain was followed in turn by poor sleep that night.³ Depression scores influenced both directions.

That bidirectionality is good news, oddly, because it means the loop has two entry points and one of them is more tractable than the other. You cannot decide to have less pain tomorrow. You can change several things about tonight.

Why sleep is where I would start with most people. It is measurable within days rather than months. It affects fatigue, fog, and mood as well as pain. And improvement compounds, because a better night lowers tomorrow's pain, which makes tomorrow night easier.

The size of the claim. Of all the loops running, this is the one where effort pays back soonest, and starting where the leverage is beats starting where the frustration is. That is a claim about where to start, not a promise that fixing sleep fixes fibromyalgia.

The practical specifics on eating for sleep are in the companion diet guide, and the supplement guide covers the supplement options with their evidence and interaction warnings.

Movement helps, and doing it wrong sets you back for weeks

This is the key where generic advice does the most harm, so I want to be precise.

Movement has real evidence. A 2026 systematic review and meta-analysis of 23 randomized trials covering 1,734 participants found that mindful movement approaches beat control conditions across measures including fatigue, with a standardized mean difference of 0.63.⁴ Notably, sleep quality was one of the measures where the benefit did not hold, which is a useful reminder that no single intervention covers everything. A separate 2026 analysis of 21 trials with 1,638 participants compared aerobic exercise, resistance training, and other modalities directly.⁵

So the open question is how to move.

The mistake almost everyone makes. You have a good day. You feel briefly like yourself. You do everything you have been putting off. And then you lose the next three days, or the next week, and conclude that exercise makes fibromyalgia worse.

What made it worse was the dose, which was set by how you felt in the moment rather than by what you could reliably repeat.

Pace by what is repeatable, not by capacity. The practical version: find the amount you could do on a bad day, do that amount on every day including good ones, and increase it slowly when the baseline itself has moved. This feels absurdly conservative for the first few weeks. It is also the difference between a line that trends up and a sawtooth that goes nowhere for years.

A specific and important caution. If you experience post-exertional malaise, meaning a delayed and disproportionate crash in the day or two after activity, do not follow a graded exercise programme that requires steady weekly increases regardless of symptoms. That prescription has caused real harm in people with post-exertional malaise. Pacing is the approach that fits, and the distinction is not academic.

Stress is part of the mechanism, and that is not the same as it being your fault

This key gets skipped in a lot of patient material because it is easy to say badly. I would rather say it carefully than leave it out.

The nervous system that processes pain is the same one that runs your stress response. They are not separate systems that occasionally interact. A system held in a state of threat processes sensory input differently, and it does so through physical mechanisms, not attitude.

What follows from that, and what does not.

It follows that stress load genuinely affects symptom intensity, that this is worth working with, and that approaches aimed at the nervous system rather than the tissue have a legitimate place.

It does not follow that fibromyalgia is caused by stress, that you brought it on yourself, or that you could think your way out of it if you tried harder. That framing is both wrong and cruel, and if a clinician has offered it to you, they were wrong.

There is a related trap on the other side. Because stress is part of the mechanism, some people conclude the whole problem is psychological and go looking for a psychological cure. Psychological approaches help with the suffering and the disability, and they are worth doing. They do not switch off central sensitisation.

What the medications actually do, including the part your prescriber may not have mentioned

Pregabalin, duloxetine, and milnacipran are the three drugs FDA-approved for fibromyalgia in the United States. Here is what the evidence actually shows about them, which is more sobering than their approval status suggests.

The Cochrane review of SNRIs for fibromyalgia concluded, on low to very low quality evidence, that duloxetine and milnacipran provided **no clinically relevant benefit over placebo** in the frequency of achieving 50% or greater pain relief. They did show benefit on patients' global impression of being much or very much improved.⁶ That is a meaningful distinction: people felt better overall more often than they achieved substantial pain reduction.

And a network meta-analysis of 36 studies covering 11,930 patients compared amitriptyline, an old and inexpensive generic used off-label, against the three FDA-approved options.⁷ Compared with placebo, amitriptyline was associated with reduced sleep disturbance and reduced fatigue, with standardized mean differences of 0.97 and 0.64 respectively. Those are respectable numbers for the drug that is not the approved one.

What I want you to take from this. Not that you should stop a medication, and not that you should start one. None of these are things I prescribe. They are included here so you know what exists and can raise it with the physician managing that part of your care. Both starting and stopping are decisions for you and your prescriber, and stopping a psychiatric or neurological medication abruptly on the strength of a book is a genuinely bad idea.

What I want you to take is that the approved-versus-off-label distinction reflects who ran trials for an indication, not a clean ranking of what works. If a medication is helping you, that is real regardless of what the pooled data says about averages. If one is not helping after a fair trial at an adequate dose, the fact that it is FDA-approved for your condition does not obligate you to keep taking it, and that is a conversation worth having rather than a verdict to accept.

The comorbidities are not coincidences

Fibromyalgia travels with a specific set of companions, and treating them as separate problems handled by separate specialists is how people end up with six providers and no plan.

The usual cluster includes irritable bowel syndrome, migraine or chronic headache, temporomandibular joint pain, restless legs, interstitial cystitis or bladder pain, anxiety and depression, and orthostatic symptoms such as dizziness on standing.

These are not unrelated bad luck. They share the sensitization mechanism. A nervous system amplifying signals from muscle also amplifies signals from gut, bladder, and blood vessels. Recognizing that reframes the situation usefully: you do not have seven conditions, you have one process expressing itself in seven places.

Practically, that means two things. An intervention aimed at the underlying process can improve several of them at once, which is why sleep and pacing show up repeatedly. And symptoms should still be evaluated individually rather than attributed to fibromyalgia by default, because people with fibromyalgia also get appendicitis and thyroid disease like everyone else. Attributing everything to the diagnosis is the mirror-image error of attributing nothing to it.

What realistic improvement actually looks like

I would rather give you an accurate picture than an inspiring one, because inaccurate expectations are how people conclude they have failed at something that was never on offer.

What is realistic. Meaningfully fewer bad days. Bad days that are less severe and shorter. More predictability, which matters more than most people expect, because unpredictability is what makes planning impossible and planning is what makes a life. Better function at the same pain level, which is a real win even though it does not look like one on a pain scale. Improvement measured over months and seasons rather than weeks.

What is not realistic. A cure. A pain-free baseline. A single intervention that resolves it. Linear progress without setbacks.

How to tell whether something is working, given all of that. Not by how you feel on any given day, which is noise. By whether the trend over a month has moved, by whether your bad days are less bad, and by whether you can do more before symptoms escalate.

This is precisely why tracking matters more in fibromyalgia than in most conditions. The changes are gradual, memory is unreliable about gradual change in both directions, and without a record you are left comparing today against an inaccurate memory of six months ago. That comparison usually understates real improvement, which then gets abandoned as useless.

A staged roadmap

Not a protocol, and not a schedule you are failing if you deviate from. An order of operations that puts effort where it pays back soonest.

First, establish the baseline and rule out the mimics. Get the testing done properly, with the request list from the companion lab guide if that helps. Start tracking before changing anything, so you have a real starting point rather than a remembered one.

Then work on sleep, because it has the shortest feedback loop and it lowers tomorrow's pain.

Next, establish a repeatable movement floor, set by what you could do on a bad day, held steady for several weeks before it moves.

Then, one at a time, run the specific experiments in the companion diet and supplement guides. The single-change rule is not a stylistic preference. Running four changes at once produces a feeling instead of a finding.

Reassess at three months, not three weeks. Fibromyalgia moves on a slower clock than most conditions, and judging an intervention at two weeks will make you abandon things that would have worked.

Take the next step: your free Root Discovery Session

If you have read this far, you probably have a version of the same question: which of these applies to me, and in what order.

That is the conversation a book cannot have with you. It cannot see your labs, your medication list, which symptom is costing you most, or which of the mimics has actually been ruled out rather than assumed.

Book a free Root Discovery Session: rootcauseunlocked.com/discovery

There is no obligation to continue, and if your case belongs with someone else, I will tell you so.

Consultations and ongoing care are both available wherever you are located. Being outside North Carolina is not a barrier to working with me. Tell me where you are when you reach out and I will lay out exactly how we would work together from there.

Get in touch: rootcauseunlocked.com/contact

If you would rather start on your own, start tracking: rootcauseunlocked.com/tracker

The tracker is free, works anywhere, and your entries stay on your own device. Given how much of managing fibromyalgia depends on seeing a trend you cannot feel day to day, this is genuinely one of the higher-value things you can do this week, and it costs nothing.

Disclaimer

This book is educational. It does not constitute medical advice, diagnosis, or treatment, and reading it does not establish a patient-provider relationship. Nothing here is a reason to start, stop, or change a prescription on your own. Fibromyalgia shares symptoms with several conditions that are treated differently, which is why the testing chapter exists and why an accurate diagnosis belongs with a clinician who has examined you.

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Working with Root Health

This guide is general education by design, written so it is useful without knowing anything about your labs. Personalized work is different. It starts with testing, your history, your medication list, and the symptoms costing you the most, then sequences changes instead of piling them on.

If you want that, a Root Discovery Session is free and is the right first step. Book at rootcauseunlocked.com/discovery.

Consultations and ongoing care are both available wherever you are located. Being outside North Carolina is not a barrier to working with me. Tell me where you are when you reach out and I will lay out exactly how we would work together from there.

If you would rather start on your own, the symptom tracker at rootcauseunlocked.com/tracker is free and works anywhere. In fibromyalgia it does real work, because the changes are gradual and memory is an unreliable instrument across weeks.

Reach me at (919) 662-0520 or at 503 US-70 East, Suite L, Garner, NC 27529.